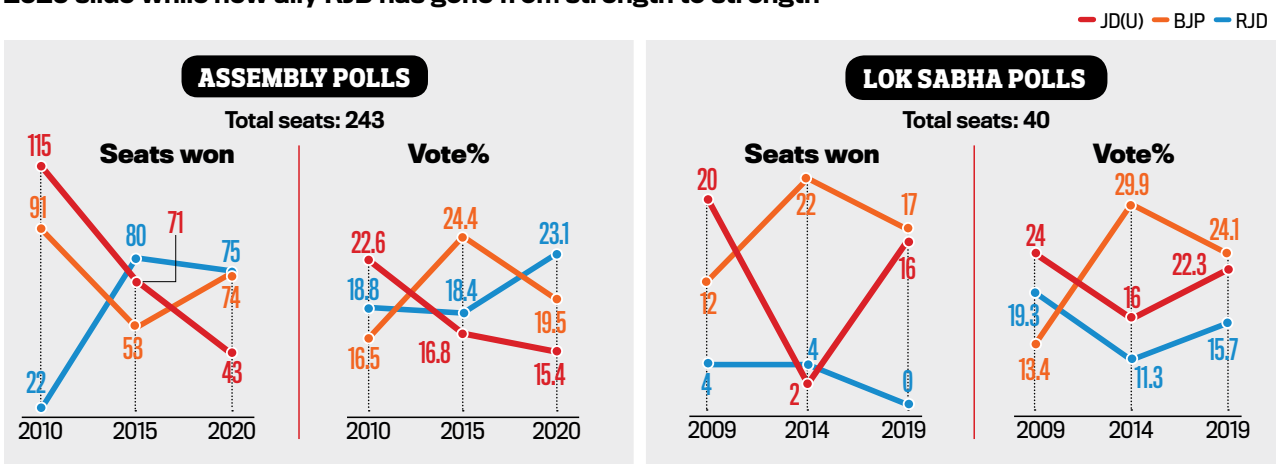
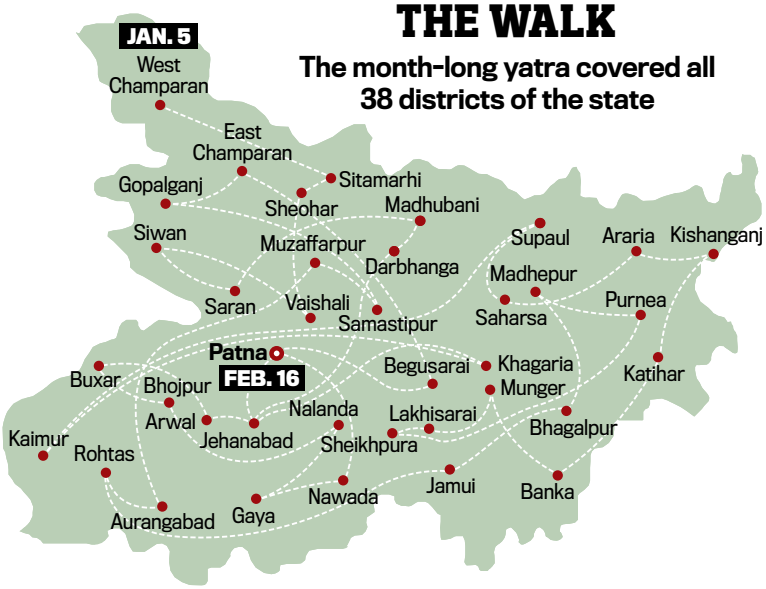
THE UNEVEN SCALES

Nitish's JD(U) has used its alliances to good effect except for the 2020 slide while new ally RJD has gone from strength to strength



NITISH WALKS THE WALK

The month-long yatra covered all 38 districts of the state



per cent Paswan voters to the saffron kitty. Still smarting from the way the JD(U) boss ditched them last August, they will do everything to deal a body blow to the party in the general election. Meanwhile, current alliance partner and Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief Tejashwi Yadav—whom Nitish has nominated as his successor—will be eager to lead the grand alliance and cement his credentials as a CM candidate.

The Samadhan Yatra is an attempt to revive the support base that has stood by Nitish in the past two decades, convey to them that he is grateful, that his government has come to their doorstep. At a more subtle level, with officials at his beck and call, it is also to send a message to the people—critics can say what they want but Nitish is the one who calls the shots in Bihar. "He is very much in the thick of things. He is the boss, and will remain so at least till 2025. That's the underlying narrative here," says a top JD(U) leader.

The political strategy is also clear. Apart from his traditional support base of Kurmi-Kushwaha and Extremely Backward Class (EBC) voters, Nitish is also attempting to win over the women as a caste-neutral constituency once again. Which is why at every district he crossed, the CM made it a point to spend time with members of the state's 13 million-strong Jeevika women's self-help group (SHG) community (see *Women hold up the Centre*).

The numerically crucial Mahadalits, the most marginalised among the scheduled castes (SCs), have also been a special focus area. The SC community, divided among 22 sub-castes, make up around 15 per cent of Bihar's population. Since 2007, when Nitish created a special Mahadalits category, making 21 of these sub-castes beneficiaries of various government schemes, he has been favoured by the community. It was clear during the yatra that he was, literally, walking the extra mile to consolidate this time-tested support base. If the BJP can bank on Chirag's Paswan voters, Nitish was trying to ensure that the *mahagathbandhan* (MGB) alliance cornered the remainder of the SC pie.

OTHER CHALLENGES

The 2020 assembly election came as a reality check for the JD(U), when for the first time, the party saw its tally come down to 43 seats (out of a total of 243), placing it a distant third behind the RJD and BJP. While followers in the Nitish camp attributed the losses to then ally BJP clandestinely transferring their votes to Chirag's LJP, assembly polls almost inevitably trigger some